CHAPTER 4

THINKERS BELIEFS AND BUILDINGS

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master 6th century BCE philosophical ferment: Vedic sacrificial traditions, Jainism (Vardhamana Mahavira), Buddhism (Gautama Buddha), Sangha organization, Sanchi Stupa preservation, and early temple architecture.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Mid-First Millennium BCE Ferment:** Global philosophical awakening (Zarathustra in Iran, Socrates in Greece, Buddha and Mahavira in India); emergence of Kutagarashalas where philosophers debated life's meaning.

• **Jain Philosophy and Ahimsa:** Vardhamana Mahavira (24th Tirthankara); fundamental premise that the entire world is animated; supreme emphasis on Ahimsa (non-injury to living beings, plants, insects), karma, and monastic vows.

• **Buddhist Philosophy and the Sangha:** Gautama Buddha taught Four Noble Truths and Eightfold Path (Majjhima Patipada - Middle Path); founded the Sangha for monks (bhikkhus) and nuns (bhikkhunis); split into Hinayana and Mahayana.

• **Stupa Architecture and Sanchi Preservation:** Stupas built over Buddha's bodily relics (Anda, Harmika, Yashti, Chhatri); Sanchi Stupa survived thanks to Shahjehan Begum and Sultan Jehan Begum funding plaster-cast preservation.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Four Noble Truths} \iff \text{Dukkha (Suffering)} \to \text{Samudaya (Cause)} \to \text{Nirodha (Cessation)} \to \text{Magga (Path)}$$

Buddhist Philosophical Foundation of Human Liberation

$$\text{Jain Ethical Code} \iff \text{Ahimsa (Non-Violence)} + \text{Satya} + \text{Asteya} + \text{Brahmacharya} + \text{Aparigraha}$$

Five Great Vows (Mahavratas) of Jain Monasticism

$$\text{Stupa Anatomy} \iff \text{Anda (Mound)} + \text{Harmika (Balcony)} + \text{Yashti (Spire)} + \text{Toranas (Gateways)}$$

Cosmological Architecture of Buddhist Stupa

$$\text{Sanchi Preservation Victory} \iff \text{Bhopal Begums Subsidies} \to \text{Museum} + \text{Preserved Original}$$

Nineteenth-Century Indian Heritage Conservation Triumph

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Amaravati Stupa was ruined because British officials carted away marble sculptures to Madras, London, and Calcutta; Sanchi survived because Bhopal Begums funded plaster-cast replicas for European museums.

• **Alert:** Ananda persuaded the Buddha to allow women into the Sangha; Mahapajapati Gotami (Buddha's foster mother) was the first woman ordained as a bhikkhuni.

• **Alert:** In Hinayana (Theravada), Buddha was revered as an enlightened human teacher; in Mahayana, Buddha was worshipped as a divine saviour alongside Bodhisattvas.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Why did Sanchi survive while Amaravati was destroyed? Discuss the role of the Begums of Bhopal. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Destruction of Amaravati:** Discovered in the late 18th century; local rulers used bricks for masonry, and British antiquarians removed exquisitely carved marble panels to Calcutta and London. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Role of Bhopal Begums:** Shahjehan Begum and Sultan Jehan Begum provided funds to maintain the site, built a guesthouse and museum, and sponsored John Marshall's research volumes. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Wise Cultural Defence:** When the French and British sought the Eastern Gateway for European museums, the Begums provided plaster-cast copies, preserving the original at Sanchi. **[1 Mark]**

2. Explain the core teachings of Gautama Buddha. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. World is Anicca and Anatta:** The world is transient (anicca), constantly changing, and soulless (anatta); there is nothing permanent or eternal. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Sorrows and the Middle Path:** Human sorrow is intrinsic to existence; by following the Middle Path (Majjhima Patipada) between severe penance and indulgence, one rises above worldly troubles. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **3. Extinction of Ego (Nibbana):** Right conduct and meditation extinguish desire and ego, ending the cycle of rebirth and suffering. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. Describe the main principles of Jain philosophy. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Living Nature of the World:** Even rocks, stones, and water possess life; supreme duty is Ahimsa (non-injury to humans, animals, plants, or insects). **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Cycle of Karma:** One's birth and rebirth are determined by past karma; asceticism and severe penance are required to liberate oneself from karma. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Monastic Discipline:** Monks take five vows: not to kill, not to lie, not to steal, observe celibacy, and not to possess property. **[1 Mark]**

4. Explain the architectural components of a Buddhist Stupa. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Anda:** The semi-circular hemispherical earthen and brick mound representing the universe. **[1 Mark]**

• **Harmika and Yashti:** The square balcony-like structure atop the mound (Harmika) representing the abode of the gods, supporting a central mast (Yashti) crowned by an umbrella (Chhatri). **[1 Mark]**

• **Railings and Toranas:** Enclosed by a circular stone railing (vedika) with four elaborately carved monumental gateways (Toranas) oriented to the four cardinal directions. **[1 Mark]**

5. Who was the first woman admitted into the Buddhist Sangha? At whose persuasion did the Buddha admit women? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **First Woman:** Mahapajapati Gotami, the foster mother of the Buddha, ordained as the first bhikkhuni. **[1 Mark]**

• **Persuaded By:** Ananda, the favorite disciple of the Buddha. **[1 Mark]**

6. Distinguish between Hinayana (Theravada) and Mahayana Buddhism. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Hinayana:** Emphasizes individual self-effort to attain nirvana, revering Buddha as an exemplary human teacher. **[1 Mark]**

• **Mahayana:** Believes in the divinity of the Buddha as a saviour god and worships compassionate Bodhisattvas who delay their own enlightenment to save all living beings. **[1 Mark]**